Conclusions & Generalizations - Study Guide

Combine several details to reach a careful conclusion - then apply the underlying idea without overgeneralizing.

Learning goal	Synthesize details into a defensible conclusion or generalization, and reject answers that are too narrow, too broad, or based on an unsupported prediction.

A conclusion uses the whole pattern

A conclusion is stronger than an inference from one clue. It often requires several details, results, or main ideas to be considered together. A good conclusion explains the pattern without claiming more than the passage supports.

A generalization carries a supported idea into a closely related situation. The key is to transfer the underlying principle, not just match the surface topic. If a passage shows that repeated short practice improves a skill, a new situation involving repeated short practice may fit even if the subject is different.

Too narrow	Supported	Too broad
Only one detail	Combines the important pattern	Claims a universal rule
"The Tuesday group improved."	"Groups that practiced briefly several times improved more consistently than the one-time practice group in this trial."	"Short practice always works better for everyone."

Question language to recognize

- Which conclusion is best supported by the passage as a whole?
- What can be concluded from the results?
- Which generalization is supported by the examples?
- Which new situation best illustrates the same principle?

A reliable method

1. List two or three details that point in the same direction.
2. Write a conclusion that fits all of them.
3. Check scope: remove words such as always, never, all, or definitely unless the passage truly supports them.
4. For transfer questions, identify the principle first, then choose a new situation with the same relationship - not just the same topic.

The scope test	Ask: "Could this conclusion be true if one supporting detail disappeared?" If it relies on only one detail, it may be too narrow. If it goes beyond every detail, it may be too broad.

Worked example

Example	A school tested three reminder systems for returning borrowed laptops. A weekly poster produced little change. A text reminder sent one day before the due date reduced late returns. A text reminder plus a short confirmation reply reduced late returns even further. The school tested the systems for eight weeks.

1. Which conclusion is best supported?

A. Posters never work for any school message

B. In this trial, direct reminders - especially those requiring a response - were associated with fewer late returns

C. Every student prefers text messages

D. Laptop borrowing should end

Answer: B	B combines the pattern across all three systems and keeps the conclusion limited to the evidence from this trial.

Common traps

- A conclusion based on one memorable detail instead of the overall pattern.
- An absolute statement that turns a limited result into a universal rule.
- A prediction about something the passage never measured.
- A transfer answer that shares the same topic but not the same underlying relationship.

Quick check

Mini text	Three classes used the same vocabulary list. Class A studied for forty minutes once. Class B studied ten minutes on four different days. Class C studied five minutes on eight different days. On a test one week later, Classes B and C remembered more words than Class A.

1. Which conclusion is best supported?

A. Long study sessions never help anyone

B. In this comparison, spreading practice across days was associated with better later recall

C. Class C will remember every word for a year

D. Vocabulary lists are ineffective

Answer: B. It describes the pattern and stays within the study conditions.

Diagnostic help

Use the mistake pattern to decide what to change on your next question.

1. **If: You choose a conclusion that is much broader than the evidence.**

   Try: Match the scope of the conclusion to the scope of the examples or data. A small sample cannot support a universal claim.

2. **If: You repeat one detail instead of combining the pattern.**

   Try: Ask what the details collectively suggest. A conclusion should synthesize, not merely copy.

3. **If: You transfer the wrong surface feature to a new situation.**

   Try: Identify the underlying principle first, then choose the new example that follows the same relationship.

30-second reset

Before the next conclusions & generalizations question: restate the target, point to the evidence, and reject any choice that needs an extra assumption.